RABBENU AVRAHAM BEN HARAMBAM

What Did Sarah See? Yishmael, Hagar and a Conditional Promise

Rabbenu Avraham on Parashat Vayera

Series: Rabbenu Avraham ben HaRambam on the Parashah: ideas from Rabbenu Avraham's commentary on the Torah (which survives on Bereshit and Shemot), taught each week at the Monday HaMaspik LeOvdei HaShem shiur.

Source: Taught at the HaMaspik shiur of the week of Vayera 5787, HaMaspik 10.2.

Topic: Four ideas: what Sarah saw in **מצחק**; why Hagar feared Yishmael would die after the promise; the simple meaning of **באשר הוא שם**; and **בעת ההיא** versus **אחרי הדברים האלה**, a principle for the whole Torah.

Part One — Rabbenu Avraham on Parashat Vayera

1. What did Sarah see? — "מצחק" (Bereshit 21:9)

ותרא שרה את בן הגר המצרית אשר ילדה לאברהם מצחק.

Sarah sees the son of Hagar — Yishmael, the older brother — **מצחק**. The Torah is deliberately playing on the word: **Yishak** is named for laughter, and Yishmael is **mesahek**. But there are **two kinds of שחוק**. What was the problem?

ראתה אותו מצחק ומנבל את פיו ומתנהג כדרך הנערים.

Sarah saw him **fooling around as youngsters do — and using his mouth for inappropriate speech**. *Playing around* is understandable from the word **מצחק**; where Rabbenu Avraham gets **מנבל את פיו**, coarse language, the Rabbi doesn't know — but for some reason he adds it.

Why is that a problem? It is **מפריע מדרך השלמות** — it prevents a person from reaching perfection, as Shlomo HaMelekh said in Kohelet: **לשחוק אמרתי מהולל... טוב כעס משחוק.** *When I was younger I thought it was good to laugh around; when I was older I realised that, although anger is bad, sometimes it is better than mucking around.* It shows the dangers of **שחוק used in the wrong way**.

וחששה שמא יצחק נעתק אליו ולשחוק, בהתחברו עם ישמעאל, ויבלה זמנו שעה בלא עסק בשלמות המיוחדת לו.

Sarah was afraid **Yishak would copy Yishmael** — remember, Yishmael is older — and, instead of using his time to work on **the perfection unique to him**, would spend it playing around.

וזה הוא הראוי שיעמוד בסגולתו... ושרה מטפלת בזה, לפי ששניהם נוכחים בבית אצלה בשעת המנוחה.

Yishak's task is to work on his own perfection. There was a strong relationship between Sarah and Yishak — understandably, he is her biological child — and they spent a great deal of time

together, resting and eating together. **Very interesting:** although both are Avraham's children, Rabbenu Avraham suggests that **Sarah took personal responsibility for Yishak's spiritual development**. When she saw it threatened by Yishmael's behaviour, she felt it was time to drive Yishmael out.

Two new points from Rabbenu Avraham: (1) Yishmael was **speaking wrongly**, not just playing; (2) **Sarah saw herself as responsible** for guiding Yishak towards perfection.

2. Why did Hagar fear Yishmael would die? (21:16)

Yishmael and Hagar have been sent away with limited food and water, and run out. Hagar distances herself: **כי אמרה אל אראה במות הילד** — *"I don't want to see my child die."*

The question: In **last week's parashah, Lekh Lekha**, the malakh told Hagar that Yishmael would grow up and become a nation — **ידו בכל** — prominent and influential. So what is she worried about? How will he become a nation if he dies now? *A strong question.*

> **אין זה ספק מצדה בהבטחתו יתעלה שהבטיח לה, והוא יהיה פרא אדם ידו בכל ויד כל בו, אלא על דרך יראת אברהם ויעקב עליהם השלום... כשסבר שמא יגרום החטא.**

The easy answer would be that Hagar doubted — she lacked proper emunah. **Rabbenu Avraham is not comfortable with that.** He is convinced Hagar *did* trust the message. Rather — as the Rambam says (we learned it together in **Shemonah Perakim**, and it appears in many other sefarim) — **שמא יגרום החטא**: even when one has been promised something, **such promises are often conditional**. If a person misbehaves, he can lose them.

So she had **full faith** in the promise — and at the same time feared that **sin** (Yishmael's, her own, or both) could stop it.

A question from Mark: *The obvious parallel is the Akedah. Avraham was promised Yishak would become a great nation — and then told to slaughter him.*

The Rabbi: Someone (he couldn't recall who) says that this was **part of the test** itself: *you've been told clearly that you and your son will become a great nation — will you now doubt that prophecy?* Avraham didn't doubt, and went ahead. Whatever one answers for Avraham and Yishak, answer the same for Hagar and Yishmael. *Fair point.*

3. "באשר הוא שם" — the simple meaning (21:17)

> **וישמע אלהים את קול הנער, ויקרא מלאך אלהים אל הגר מן השמים... אל תיראי כי שמע אלהים אל קול הנער באשר הוא שם.**

The well-known interpretation (Hazal — the one we discuss on Rosh Hashanah): *where he is now* — although Yishmael will later do bad things, **at this moment** his identity is good, and he is judged as he is now.

But, says Rabbenu Avraham, that is not the simple reading:

> **פשטי דקרא, שהביט הקדוש ברוך הוא יתעלה במצבו וצערו שהוא בו, במקום שבו עזבתו אמו — תחת אחד השיחים.**

Geographically, not spiritually: Hashem heard the child crying **where he physically was** — abandoned, alone, under one of the bushes. *"I always read the verse as 'where he is now'.*

That's why I wanted to share it with you."

4. "ויהי בעת ההיא" vs "אחרי הדברים האלה" — a principle for the whole Torah

After Yishmael grows up in the wilderness, the Torah says **ויהי בעת ההיא** — *and it was at that time* — and moves to the covenant between Avraham and Avimelekh. What does *at that time* mean?

ויהי בעת ההיא — מורה על הזמן שלא הוגדר במקרא, שהוא כינוי החוזר על העת, ואותה העת לא הוגדרה; ואפשר שתהיה העת מורה על הזמן של הסיפור שקדם זכרונו, או... על הזמן של הסיפור שיבוא אחר כך.

Phrase	Meaning
"at that time" — **ויהי בעת ההיא**	**Vague.** It may refer to the story **before** it, or to the story **after** it. We simply don't know.
after these" — **אחרי הדברים האלה** "things	**Defined.** It always refers to the time of the story itself.

this I have from my father (the Rambam). The Rabbi has not — **וזה פירוש שאני מעתיק מן אבא מרי** .seen this anywhere in the Rambam's own writings; this may be its only source

The proof — Devarim, Parashat Eikev:

ובני ישראל נסעו מבארות בני יעקן מוסרה, שם מת אהרן ויקבר שם, ויכהן אלעזר בנו תחתיו... בעת ההיא הבדיל ה' את שבט הלוי.

- Aharon's death is in **the 40th year** after leaving Egypt.
- Straight afterwards: **בעת ההיא** Hashem separated the tribe of Levi — which happened in **the 2nd year** (Korach / the inauguration of the Leviim).

So **בעת ההיא** is open-ended. In Vayera, **ויהי בעת ההיא** could refer back to the whole narrative of Yishmael in the desert, or forward to the covenant with Avimelekh — but **not** necessarily to either.

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